Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Frost's "Riders"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the controlling image in Robert Frost's poem "Riders" include

alliteration,
ambiguity,
controlling image,
feminine rhyme,
iambic pentameter,
imagery,
masculine rhyme,
metaphor,
paradox,
quatrain,
rhetorical question,
synecdoche,
theme, and
tone.

The controlling image of Frost's "Riders," that we are riders on a journey through life, should give the young writer little trouble.

The earth as horse and the individual as bareback rider constitute the foundation-metaphor, the controlling image, that is anchored in the displacing of the "mystery" of birth (line 5) through the imagery of the infant taking naturally to the challenge that is life/living/perhaps, exploring: "His small fist buried in the bushy hide" (line 8). There is no mystery: we are here to ride, even if the mount "runs unbridled off its course" (line 10).

The student might recognize the range of potential experience—"land and tide / And now the very air" (lines 3-4), a phrasing that also suggests the opportunities that are offered to us as riders and as guiders (line 2): both as individuals and as humankind through the course of history into the age of flight (the ***now*** in line 4's "And now the very air").

The connotations associated with the metaphorical imagery "headless horse" and "run[ning] off its course" (lines 9-10) reinforce the "defied blandishments" of line 11: we might be encouraged as riders, or we might, as guiders, encourage others. Not everything works out (lines 9-11), and the opportunities continue: "We have ideas yet that we haven't tried" (line 12).

The contestant who is conscious of Frost's inclination to match, in some way, a poem's subject or its theme with the characteristics of poetic expression might point to the implied balance and stability of the rhymed iambic pentameter against the "seeming" (line 11) wild ride that is our living on this earth.